

"Gifts can be dangerous and make a nation dependent on foreign aid. They can scuttle dairy development here."

WHITE KNIGHT

The world was sceptical of his plan to take technology to the smallest farmer but the iconoclastic Milkman of India never gave up

Verghese Kurien

Dairy expert 1921

■ By Yoginder K. Alagh

The Green Revolution was initiated with the import of high yielding plant varieties in the '60s, but could only consolidate itself in the mid-'70s with policies that were to give quick returns to the farmer and provide them new technologies for irrigation and seed replication. The world was then sceptical, but we, who were involved in planning for food security, knew that if the environment was right, small farmers would benefit. Economists Vijai Vyas and G.S. Bhalla proved that the revolution was not enough. The villages needed more income. It was then that the Milkman of India began working for that with a tenacity which

made him an icon. His model was even more iconoclastic.

But in 1978, FAO dismissed Verghese Kurien's idea of taking technology to the small farmer. Dairying, it said, was for the corporates. However, they could not stop him. With that non-normal idea, his National Dairy Development Board (NDDB) took India's milk production from an annual growth of 0.5 per cent to 5 per cent. By 1998, India became the world's largest milk producer.

Armed with an American degree, Kurien somewhat unwillingly went to Anand in May 1949, and the rest, as they say, is history. In 1973, NDDB helped set up the Gujarat Cooperative Milk Marketing Federation for selling the products produced by cooperative

milk unions in the state under the brand names Amul and Sagar. In 1988, it facilitated the restructuring of the National Cooperative Dairy Federation of India to provide a national body for state dairy cooperatives.

Kurien has always drawn attention to the fallacies of India's new economic policies. The market, he says, does not allocate resources for the disadvantaged. His global vision is that of collaboration between the north and south, and to help build agro-industries in Africa, Asia and Latin America. He dreams of an Operation Worldwide Flood which can help tens of millions of farmers in the world.

The author is a former Union minister



Q: At what position did he start his career in the dairy industry?

A: Dairy engineer

Q: What was Amul initially called?

A: Kaira District Cooperative Milk Producers' Union Limited

Q: Which discipline of engineering does he specialise in?

A: Mechanical engineering



VIVAN MEHRA